

FREE RESOURCE · LEAD MAGNET

The Founder Sales & Systems Checklist

Find out what's actually stopping your business from growing.

Offer Clarity

Visibility

Lead Capture

Sales

Systems

Partnerships

Community

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Founder, Early Founders Collective

TOTAL SCORE

/ 35

7 sections · 4 questions each

INTRODUCTION

Most businesses are stuck because of one or two bottlenecks.

Most founders do not need another idea. They do not need more motivation, more content to consume, or another course to buy. What they need is clarity on what is actually broken inside their business right now.

This checklist was built for one purpose: to help you quickly identify the one or two areas that are quietly limiting your growth — so you can stop guessing and start fixing.

It covers seven core areas of a functioning business: your offer, your visibility, how you capture leads, how you sell, your systems, your partnerships, and your community. Each section is scored out of five. Your total score out of 35 will tell you exactly where to focus your energy.

Be honest with yourself as you go through it. The more accurate your answers, the more useful this becomes.

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

1

Read each question and check the box if the answer is honestly yes.

2

Count your checkmarks per section and record your score (0–5).

3

Add up all seven sections for your total score out of 35.

4

Use the score guide and reflection prompts to build your 30-day plan.

Section 01 OFFER CLARITY

Offer Clarity

If people do not immediately understand what you sell and why it matters, they will not buy it — no matter how good it actually is.

☐

Someone can explain what you sell in one clear sentence.

Ask a friend or family member to describe your business. If they struggle, your messaging needs work.

☐

Customers understand the value of your offer quickly — without a long explanation.

A strong offer communicates its value within the first 10 seconds of exposure.

☐

You serve a specific, well-defined audience — not everyone.

Trying to serve everyone is the fastest way to connect with no one.

☐

People know why they should choose you over the alternatives.

Your unique selling point is clear, specific, and believable — not just "great service."

SECTION SCORE

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Circle your score

Section 02 VISIBILITY

Visibility

A great offer that nobody sees is the same as no offer at all. Visibility is not about going viral — it is about showing up consistently where your customers already are.

☐ You are consistently showing up online — at least 3 times per week.

Consistency builds trust. Sporadic posting builds nothing.

☐ New people regularly discover your business without you personally reaching out to them.

This means your content, SEO, referrals, or partnerships are doing some of the work for you.

☐ People can easily find you when they search for what you do.

Google your business category and your name. Are you showing up?

☐ You create content that educates, attracts, or builds trust with your target audience.

Content does not have to be daily. It has to be intentional and relevant to the people you want to reach.

SECTION SCORE

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Circle your score

Section 03 LEAD CAPTURE

Lead Capture

Visibility without a clear next step is just entertainment. Lead capture is the bridge between someone discovering your business and them becoming a paying customer.

- ☐ You have a website or landing page that clearly explains what you do and who it is for.

It does not need to be fancy. It needs to be clear, fast, and mobile-friendly.

- ☐ You have a lead form or contact mechanism that makes it easy for interested people to reach you.

If there is no obvious way to take the next step, most people will not take it.

- ☐ You are actively collecting email addresses from interested prospects.

Email is still the highest-converting channel for most businesses. Social media followers are rented. Email lists are owned.

- ☐ There is a clear, defined next step for someone who is interested but not yet ready to buy.

A free resource, a discovery call, a newsletter, or a community — something that keeps them in your world.

SECTION SCORE

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Circle your score

Section 04 SALES

Sales

Revenue does not happen by accident. A business without a repeatable sales process is just a hobby with overhead. This section measures whether your sales engine is actually running.

☐ **You have a repeatable, documented sales process — not just winging it every time.**
From first contact to closed deal, you know the steps and you follow them consistently.

☐ **You know your conversion rate — how many leads become paying customers.**
If you do not know this number, you cannot improve it. Even a rough estimate is better than nothing.

☐ **You follow up consistently with leads who have not yet made a decision.**
Most sales happen between the 5th and 12th follow-up. Most founders stop after one or two.

☐ **You directly and confidently ask for the sale — without over-explaining or apologizing.**
If you are not asking, you are not selling. Clarity and confidence close deals.

SECTION SCORE

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Circle your score

Section 05 SYSTEMS

Systems

If your business cannot function without you in it every day, you do not own a business — you own a job. Systems are what turn a founder-dependent operation into a scalable company.

- ☐ **Your business can operate — at least partially — without you being present for every task.**

A team member, contractor, or automated tool can handle at least some of your core processes.

- ☐ **You have Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) for your most repeated tasks.**

If you had to hire someone tomorrow, they could learn the job from your documentation.

- ☐ **You use automation tools to handle repetitive tasks — scheduling, invoicing, follow-ups, or reminders.**

You should not be manually doing anything that a \$30/month tool can do for you.

- ☐ **You document your processes as you build them — not just in your head.**

Written processes survive team changes, vacations, and growth. Mental processes do not.

SECTION SCORE

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Circle your score

Section 06 PARTNERSHIPS

Partnerships

The fastest path to growth is often through someone who already has the audience you need. Strategic partnerships and referral relationships are one of the most underused growth levers in early-stage businesses.

- ☐ **You have at least one or two active strategic partners who send you business.**
These are businesses or individuals who serve your same audience but do not compete with you directly.

- ☐ **Referrals come in consistently — not just occasionally from personal connections.**
If referrals only come from friends and family, you do not yet have a referral system. You have a favor network.

- ☐ **You are actively building relationships with complementary businesses in your market.**
Joint ventures, co-marketing, cross-referrals, and collaborations are all on the table.

SECTION SCORE

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Circle your score

Section 07 COMMUNITY

Community

Businesses that build community do not just acquire customers — they create advocates. When people feel connected to your brand, they return, refer, and defend you without being asked.

- ☐ **Customers feel genuinely connected to your brand — not just transactional about it.**

They follow you, engage with your content, or talk about you in ways that go beyond the product or service itself.

- ☐ **People talk about your business to others — without you asking them to.**

Word of mouth is the oldest and most powerful form of marketing. It only happens when people genuinely love what you do.

- ☐ **Customers come back — repeat business is a meaningful part of your revenue.**

Retention is almost always cheaper than acquisition. If people are not returning, something about the experience needs attention.

SECTION SCORE

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Circle your score

SCORE INTERPRETATION

What does your score mean?

0–10

SCORE

Foundation Issues

Your business has significant gaps in the core areas that drive growth. This is not a criticism — it is a clear signal. You are likely working very hard but not seeing results because the fundamentals are not yet in place. The good news is that fixing foundation issues creates the biggest and fastest improvements.

→ **Focus on Offer Clarity and Lead Capture first. Everything else builds on these two.**

11–20

SCORE

Growth Bottlenecks

You have some things working, but specific bottlenecks are limiting your growth. You may have a good offer but inconsistent visibility, or strong sales skills but no system behind them. At this stage, identifying and removing the one or two biggest blockers will unlock disproportionate growth.

→ **Look at your two lowest-scoring sections. Those are your bottlenecks. Fix them first.**

21–30

SCORE

Optimization Needed

Your business has a solid foundation and is generating results, but there is meaningful room to improve efficiency, consistency, and scale. You are likely doing many things right but doing some of them manually, inconsistently, or without clear metrics. This is the stage where systems and partnerships pay the biggest dividends.

→ **Systematize what is working. Automate what is repeatable. Delegate what is not your highest value.**

31–35

SCORE

Strong Foundation

You have built a genuinely strong operating business. Your core systems are in place, your offer is clear, and your growth levers are active. The focus at this stage shifts from building to scaling — expanding your reach, deepening your community, and building the team and infrastructure to support the next level.

→ **Focus on scale, delegation, and community. You are ready to grow faster.**

COMMON PATTERNS

The 5 Most Common Founder Bottlenecks

**Unclear Offer**

This is the most common and most costly bottleneck. When your offer is unclear, everything downstream suffers — your marketing does not convert, your sales conversations drag on, and referrals dry up because people cannot easily explain what you do. The fix is not a better pitch. It is a clearer, more specific offer built around a specific person with a specific problem.

**Lack of Consistent Visibility**

Most founders show up in bursts — posting heavily for two weeks, then going quiet for a month. Inconsistency destroys trust and kills momentum. The algorithm rewards consistency. More importantly, your audience does too. You do not need to post every day. You need to show up on a schedule your audience can count on.

**Inconsistent Follow-Up**

Leads go cold not because they were not interested — but because no one followed up. Most founders send one message and wait. The reality is that most buying decisions happen after multiple touchpoints. A simple, automated follow-up sequence can recover a significant portion of lost revenue with almost no additional effort.

**Weak or Missing Systems**

When everything runs through the founder's head, the business cannot grow beyond the founder's capacity. Weak systems mean constant firefighting, inconsistent delivery, and an inability to delegate. Even simple SOPs and basic automation tools can free up 5–10 hours per week — time that goes directly back into growth activities.

**Lack of Strategic Partnerships**

REFLECTION

Founder Reflection

Use the space below to write your honest answers. Do not overthink it. The most useful insights usually come in the first 60 seconds of reflection — before your brain starts defending the status quo.

- 1** What is my biggest bottleneck right now — the one thing that, if fixed, would change everything?

- 2** What should I stop doing — tasks, habits, or commitments that are consuming time without producing results?

- 3** What is the one thing I should focus on over the next 30 days to move my business forward?

Write your answer down. A goal that lives only in your head is a wish. A goal written down is a commitment.

YOUR PATH FORWARD

The Simple Founder Growth Plan

Most growth plans fail because they are too complicated. This one is not. These five steps, executed in order and with consistency, will move any early-stage business forward. You do not need to do all five at once. Start with the one that matches your lowest score.

1

Clarify Your Offer

Write a one-sentence description of what you do, who you do it for, and what result they get. Test it on someone outside your industry. If they do not immediately understand it, rewrite it until they do. A clear offer is the foundation everything else is built on.

Write your one-liner

Define your ICP

Clarify your USP

2

Increase Your Visibility

Pick one or two channels where your ideal customers already spend time. Show up there consistently — not perfectly. Create content that educates, builds trust, or solves a small problem. Do this on a schedule you can actually maintain for 90 days straight.

Choose 1–2 channels

Set a posting schedule

Batch your content

3

Improve Your Follow-Up

Set up a simple, 3-to-5-step follow-up sequence for every lead that does not immediately convert. Use email, text, or direct message — whatever is most appropriate for your business. Automate it if possible. Most of your revenue is sitting in leads you stopped following up with.

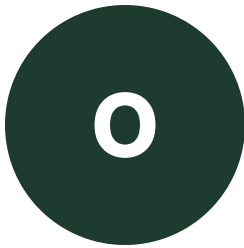
Map your follow-up steps

Set up automation

Track your pipeline

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

About Oge Madu

**Oge Madu**

Founder & Operator

Oge Madu is a multi-business founder, operator, and community builder with a track record of building from the ground up across industries. He is not a consultant who has studied entrepreneurship from the outside — he is someone who has lived it, made the mistakes, and built real businesses with real revenue.

His portfolio spans creative services, fashion, technology, real estate, and financial services. Through **Paint HTX**, he built a creative brand rooted in Houston's culture. With **SoleTies**, he entered the sneaker and lifestyle space. **Phenyx** represents his work at the intersection of technology and community. His experience in **real estate** and **mortgage** gave him a deep understanding of asset building and long-term financial strategy.

Each of these ventures taught him something different about what it actually takes to build a business — not the version you see on social media, but the real version: the systems, the sales, the pivots, and the persistence.

The **Early Founders Collective** was built out of that experience. It is a community for early-stage founders who are serious about building — people who want honest feedback, practical frameworks, and a room full of peers who are doing the same work.

VENTURES & EXPERIENCE

Paint HTX

SoleTies

Phenyx

Real Estate

Mortgage

Early Founders Collective

READY FOR THE NEXT STEP?

You Don't Need More Information. You Need A Clear Path.

If this checklist helped you identify what is holding your business back, the next step is a room full of founders who are working through the same challenges — with structure, accountability, and real peer support.

[Apply Now](#)earlyfounderscollective.com